(...) have (...) word

a reading group for word dwellers

READER
2024

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A Stolen Lexicon by Shahram Khosravi

Zagros Mountains, 1970. Photo: User "yundb" on Flickr. Accessed 20 November 2023.

1.0 DOUR / دور

Colonialism starts with language. What the colonizers steal first, are mothers' concepts.

I grew up as Bakhtiari—an Indigenous people of the Zagros mountains in South Western Iran. I was sent to school in the closest big city. The Tehrani-centric education system was based on modern Western "scientific" dogmas and canons. From the age of seven, I was told that what I had learned before that age was outdated and backwards, which made me believe that my mother was an ignorant person because, unlike what my urban teachers had taught me, she used only one word for both "lateness" and "distance."

My mother, like other Bakhtiaris, used the word dour for both spatial and temporal distance. Bakhtiaris have rimainly lived in the Zagros mountains. Known as one of the largest nomadic pastoralist groups in Iran, Bakhtiaris use the intersection of time and space as a basic dimension for their social navigations in everyday life. When talking about a specific date, it is always related to place: "the year of big flooding," "the locusts' year," "the year no frogs were seen."

Bakhtiaris use the same word for distance and lateness because of an old knowledge that time is inseparable from space. Time indeed is shaped by space: what we know as the calendar system divides time into days, months, years, and is formed through the earth's rotation within the solar system.

Geography, which is a knowledge about our relations to places and spaces, is a social

construction materialized through cartography, borders, calculations, and the measurement of distances. Time is also a social construction. When my state-centric education separated time from space, time became sorted, abstract, emptied.

Colonization does not only turn space into empty space; as unpeopled space. It also turns time into void time. When the Indigenous people of Zagros were forced into the national project of modernization, time became linear, chronological, and centralized. Accordingly, their time turned into days, weeks, and months; emptied from mountains, valleys, rivers, forests, locusts, and frogs.
Schools, alongside state-run television and popular culture, replaced mothers' and grandmothers' storytelling. We had to learn the national history from which we are excluded; placed in the "waiting room of history."[1] Modern notions of history had been created with us outside of it. We were told that we had arrived "too late."[2]
Temporal segregation and disorientation are crucial in order to segregate and displace people spatially. Our belatedness was registered with labels. We have been named as a "tribe"—first by European anthropologists and then by the Iranian authorities. "Tribe" is rooted in a racial ideology which hierarchizes different communities according to a social evolutionist typology. Within the imaginary of linear time, tribes belong to the past. A backward people. A delayed human being.

> *"Where are you from?" is not a question about geography but rather about time.*
>
> *To which part of the history of progression do you belong?*
>
> *"Are you from the now, contemporary to us?"*
>
> *or*
>
> *"Are you from the past? Backward? Contemporary with our ancestors?"*

Temporal asynchronism leads to asymmetrical spatial power relations. If a people are belated, then their land is assumed uninhabited. A vacant territory, open to be occupied. Particularly if it has vast oil reserves, like the land of the Bakhtiaris. The stealing of land and its wealth was not possible without the stealing of mothers' concepts, without systematically turning their knowledge into non-knowledge, their words into non-words.

2.0 HEIRAN / حیران

It took several decades to realize it was me who was ignorant, not my mother. I first came to this realization after learning from Indigenous peoples from other continents

how the epistemology of coloniality functions. A coloniality of power that constructs what Miranda Fricker calls "epistemic injustice."[3] Epistemic injustice means to systematically discredit the colonized person's capacity as a knower. The state-centric education I received made mothers' knowledge classified as non-knowledge. It was through interacting with Indigenous peoples from North America, Sweden, Taiwan, and South America, that I realized we are Indigenous peoples and not tribes. While the latter refers to differences and partition, the former indicates a networked history of dispossession and state violence.

This insight came late. To realize that the core tenets of my education—its schools of belief and hierarchies of knowledge—had been a tool of oppression against myself and people like myself, and that as a scholar, I was using methodologies which possessed such a history, was shocking. That I practiced and taught the same methodologies and theories which had harmed and dismantled my own people made me heiran.

Heiran means astonished and anxious. *Heiran* refers to a mood, a frame of mind, marked by confusion and fear. However, *heiran* is also a moment of revelation. To let the self into the realm of heiran is an intellectual adventure. It is to step into an unknown road with no sign or signal. It is to leave the safe and well-traveled "main road" with a clear destination, and instead enter a byroad shrouded in fog. You know you are not safe, that you might walk along the edge of the abyss. You also know that on the main road, you were already at the bottom of the abyss.[4]

To walk on the main road is what Jean-Paul Sartre called "the bad faith,"[5] to live another person's life. This bad faith denies your freedom as a knower. Bad faith is to think and act without freedom. Bad faith is when you hear your own mother's voice not as speech but as noise. To exit the main road is to reclaim your freedom as a knower. Colonial epistemologies fortify differences through the description of differences. Scientific, objective, reliable, calculative methodologies naturalize and depoliticize differences and thereby confirm certain images of the "other." The depoliticized description of difference reproduces mechanisms that confirm and reinforce practices against the racialized and "poor" other, where they are pushed to live other lives: the lives of "tribes," of "migrants," of "refugees," of the "stateless." The landscape of *heiran* is a ruinous landscape. *Heiran* emerges from ruination and loss at the same time, though it carries an intellectual curiosity and is therefore oriented towards hope. Ruination and hope are two aspects of *heiran*. *Heiran* refuses but also takes up refusal in generative ways, always meaning to open up alternative ways of knowing.

What is to be done, the methodology, when being heiran?

If *heiran* is a state of wonderment, then its conjugation is to *wonder*. To wonder is synonymous with to *speculate*. The method of heiran is "speculating the impossible," which is an attempt to understand the past and the present when all you have are

methodologies, concepts, and archives that have been constructed against you. Saidiya Hartman shows us how this speculative method manifests when one writes history from below. She coined the term "critical fabulation"[6] to describe her tools of making productive sense of the gaps and silences in official archives and narratives. Critical fabulation is an attempt at seizing fleeting images of the past in a present moment of colonial denial.[7] Inspired by the approach of working "from below" in Black feminism, the methodology of *heiran* combines research with speculative narratives in order to actualize hidden historical moments to unsettle the official narratives and to make whole what has been smashed.

3.0 MONQALEB / منقلب

While on the byroad of *heiran*—the condition of bewilderment and anxiety, of fear and confusion—one's consciousness turns upwards only to have it fall down, making them *monqaleb*. Derived from the Arabic word *inqilab*, Iranians use *enqelab* for revolution. While the etymology of revolution stems from a "rolling back" (re-volve), *enqelab* is about mutation. *Enqelab* results in becoming *monqaleb*; that is, an inner transformation. While the promises of revolution can be stolen and result in the return of despotism (like Iran in 1979), *enqelab* and one's becoming *monqaleb* engenders new subjectivities, and creates the conditions where it is possible to speculate the impossible; to imagine life beyond the ruins of nation-state systems. If we regard politics as a battle over the imagination, then it is the only battle we have a chance at winning. The battle itself, the rebellion, is the moment of liberation.

Freedom is already won during the struggle for it.

Only during rebellion can the *heiran* move from confusion to a state of consciousness, from fear to clarity, from isolation to solidarity. The urgent question is how to bring the *heiran*—with all their individual experiences—together and turn them into a collective, accumulated, historical experience of *heiran*. This relationality turns an I into a we. The characters in Albert Camus's works are *heiran*; faced with the absurdity of the world, they have only one way out: rebellion. As he writes in *The Rebel* (1951), "I revolt, therefore we are."[8]

4.0 ZAMAN / زمان

Zaman translates to time and era, though it also means a *critical moment*. A moment of opening. A moment of change. It is the quality of time, or as the Ancient Greeks named it, Kairos (in opposition to the quantified time, Chronos). *Zaman* is the time of change.

When the revolutionaries of 1830 took over the streets of Paris, they fired their weapons at the clock towers. This anti-clock revolutionary action was a symbolic protest

against capitalist ideas of "progress."
In 2020, refugees burnt down Moria, their camp in Lesvos, Greece. This was a refusal of the spatio-temporal partitioning the camp had imposed upon them. To burn down a camp is to refuse camp temporality, the temporality of refugee-ness. Protests against anti-Black racism in the United States or anti-migrant racism in Europe are protests against temporal segregation, against justice being constantly delayed, against the stealing of their time. When Iranian women began burning their compulsory veils during the Woman, Life, Freedom movement in fall 2022, they burned the symbol of a state which had delayed their access to education, the labor market, and citizenship rights. They burned the symbol of a temporal border that dispossessed them of time.

Fire the clocks!

Stop the time!

Burn down the capitalist temporality!

A temporality that is against the poor,

the Indigenous people

that is against birds, frogs, the earth!

To burn down racist and sexist temporalities is to create better futures for all. When a young woman screamed at the Budapest International Airport before she was forced onto an airplane, deported to Kabul, nobody heard what she said. Or rather no one wanted to hear; a willful act. But her words remain: "One day you will be refugees, too, like me, and on that day you will remember this day."

Her words trigger uncanniness because they unearth and unmask a possible future we do not want to imagine. Her words are unsettling as they force us to confront the fact that her past and our future are dialectically interrelated.

Ten years after the end of World War II, Aimé Césaire implied that at the end of the colonial project was Hitler. What Nazism did in Europe was what colonialism had done for centuries outside of Europe. The outcome of colonial racism was Hitler.9 The dehumanization of the colonized led to dehumanization of the colonizer.

If, at the end of the colonial project was Hitler, who is waiting for us at the end of the border project?

5.0 TAVAKOL / توکل

When I stepped onto the byroad, with neither a sign nor signal, walking in the fog, I

realized I needed other concepts, different from what my Tehrani and Swedish education had given me. I need new concepts to reconnect with my mother and her history. I need to steal back the concepts that had been stolen from me. I have to recollect concepts as a performative practice, not as a collection of isolated fragments from a completed past, but rather, as a collection of concepts in a past which is incomplete and always in a state of becoming. I need my mother's concepts as tools that can link different experiences across time and space: from colonial practices and bordering practices to fossil capitalism.

This final concept I bring forward is *tavakol*. *Tavakol ala allah*, an Islamic concept, which means to trust in God. *Tavakol* was another concept my mother insisted upon when talking to me, but I never took her words seriously. She tried to help me not lose hope in a hopeless world. My mind, shaped by a European academic education, rejected this concept. But now I want to reclaim it, though differently. *Tavakol*, for me, is part of a secular struggle for justice. *Tavakol* means to hope when there is no hope. It means to trust in solidarity and rebellion. *Tavakol* in dreaming and in recalling stolen knowledge. *Tavakol* in thinking beyond spatial and temporal bordering, in imagining a future otherwise, and a day beyond the day which has come.

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5.0 TAVAKOL / توكل

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You wait when you think it is conceiving you wait it to seed you think you can see through the dark earth the beginning of a root, the air entering with the water being poured dark earth harbouring dark taken for granted the silence and the dark the conception seedling. Chaste the silence and the dark the conception seedling. Chaste you wait you are supposed to you are to wait for the silence to break you wait for the implanting of some dark silence same constant as a field distant and close at the same time all around sound far and near at the same time you shiver some place in between one of the dandelion seedling vague air shivering just before the entire flower to burst and scatter without designated time, even before its own realization of the act, no premonition not preparation. All of a sudden. All of a sudden without warning. No holding back, no retreat, no second thought forward. Backward. There and not there. Remass and disperse. Convene and scatter.

Does not move. Not a sound. None. No sound. Do not move.

Inside the atmosphere. No access is given to sight. Invisible and hueless. Even. Still. The thickness of the air weighs. Weight upon weight. Still. Heavy, inert is duration without the knowledge of its enduring.

Does not wait. No wait. It has not the knowledge of wait. Knows not how. How to.

Affords no penetration. Hence no depth, No disruption. Hence, no time. No wait. Hence, no distance.

Full. Utter most full. Can contain no longer. Fore shadows the fullness. Still. Silence. Within moments of. The eclipse. Inside the eclipse. Both. Fulmination and concealment of light. Imminent crossing, face to face, moon before the sun pronounces. All. This. Time. To pronounce without prescribing purpose. It prescribes nothing. The time thought to have fixed, dead, reveals the very rate of the very movement. Velocity. Lentitude. Of its own larger time.

Withholds brilliance as the evanescent light of a dark pearl. Shone internally. As the light of the eclipse, both disparition. Both radiance. Mercurial light, nacrous. No matter, not the cloister of the shell. Luminous all the same. Waits the hour. To break. Then break.

For now, nothing enters. Still. No addition to the fullness. Grows, without accumulation. Augments, without increase. Abundance, Plenitude, Without gain.

Further, Further inside. Further than. To middle. Deeper. Without measure. Deeper than. Without means of measure. To core. In another tongue. Same word. Slight mutation of the same. Undefinable. Shift. Shift slightly. Into a different sound. The difference. How it discloses the air. Slight. Another word. Same. Parts of the same atmosphere. Deeper. Center. Without distance. No particular distance from center to periphery. Points of measure effaced. To begin there. There. In Media Res.

Do not move.
Not a sound. None. No sound.

Carrier, you hold in the palm of your hand the silver white spirit the lustre mass quiver and fall away from the center

one by one.
Sound.
Give up the sound.
Replace the sound.
With voice.

At a time. Stops. Returns to rest, again, in the center of your palm. You turn the seasons by the directions
South
North
West
East
Your palm a silver pool of liquid then as the seasons choose affix as stone in blue metal ice.

At times, starts again. Noise. Semblance of noise. Speech perhaps. Broken. One by one. At a time. Broken tongue. Pidgeon tongue. Semblance of speech.

You seek the night that you may render the air pure. Distillation extending breath to its utmost pure. Its first exhale at dawn to be collected. In the recesses of the leaves is an inlet of dew, clearest tears. You stow them before their fall by their own weight. You stand a column of white lustre, atoned with tears, restored in breath.

Maimed. Accident. Stutters. Almost a name.
Half a name. Almost a place. Starts. About to.
Then stops. Exhale swallowed to a sudden
arrest. Pauses. How vast this page. Stillness, the
page. Without. Can do without rests. Pause.
Without them. All. Stop start.

Earth is dark. Darker. Earth is a blue-black stone upon which moisture settles evenly, flawlessly. Dust the stone with a fine powder. Earth is dark, a blue-black substance, moisture and dust rise in a mist. Veil of dust smoke between sky and earth's boundaries. In black darkness, pale, luminant band of haze. You induce the stone by offering exchange of your own. Own flesh. Cry supplication wail resound song to the god to barter you, your sight. For the lenience. Make lenient, the immobility of sediment. Entreat with prayer to the god his eloquence. To conduct to stone. Thawing of the knotted flesh. Your speech as ransom. You crumple and sift by each handful the last enduring particle. Hands buried to earth dissolved to same dust. And you wait. Still. Having bartered away your form, now you are formless. Blind. Mute. Given to stillness to whiteness only too still. Waiting. Scribe. Diving. In whiteness beyond matter. Sight. Speech.

Cling. Cling more. At the sight of.
At last in sight at last. Cleared for the sighting.
So clear cling so fast cling fast at the site.
Clear and clearer.

Hours day sheet by sheet
one pile. Next pile. Then the next
from one pile to the next pile. One sheet below
the crack of closed door
slide piled up on the other side
no overlapping. One at a time. One sheet.
End in sight. With accumulation. Without prosper.

Earth is made porous. Earth heeds. Inward. Inception in darkness. In the blue-black body commences lument. Like firefly, a slow rhythmic relume to yet another and another opening.

The name. Half a name.
Past. Half passed.
Forgotten word leaving out a word
Letter. Letter by letter to the letter.

Open to the view. Come forth. Witness bound to no length no width no depth. Witness sees that which contains the witness in its view. Pale light cast inside the thin smoke, blowing. Then all around. No matter how sparse the emission, each subtle ascent is bared before the surrounding black screen. Then extinguish.

Emerge. Look forth. The succession of colors. Filtered beforehand to utmost. Pure. True. Stark. Foreboding. Red as never been. Bled to crimson. Trembling with its entire, the knowledge, of the given time. Given the mark of bloom, its duration. Abiding. Not more. Not less. The color that already was always was before its exhibition into sight.

Being broken. Speaking broken. Saying broken. Talk broken. Say broken. Broken speech. Pidgon tongue. Broken word. Before speak. As being said. As spoken. To be said. To say. Then speak

Immaterial now, and formless, having surrendered to dissolution limb by limb, all parts that compose a body. Liquid and marrow once swelled the muscle and bone, blood made freely the passages through innumerable entries, all give willingly to exile. From the introit, preparation is made for communion when the inhabitation should occur, of this body, by the other body, the larger body.

Stands now, an empty column of artery, of vein, fixed in stone. Void of wing. Void of hands, feet. It continues. This way. It should, with nothing to alter or break the fullness, nothing exterior to impose upon the plenitude of this void. It remains thus. For a time. Then without a visible mark of transition, it takes the identity of a duration. It stays. All chronology lost, indecipherable, the passage of time, until it is forgotten. Forgotten how it stays, how it endures.

A new sign of moisture appears in the barren column that had congealed to stone. Floods the stone from within, collects water as to a mere, layering first the very bottom.

From stone, A single stone. Column. Carved on one stone, the labor of figures. The labor of tongues. Inscribed to stone. The labor of voices.

Water inhabits the stone, conducts absorption of implantation from the exterior. In tones, the inscriptions resonate the atmosphere of the column, repeating over the same sounds, distinct words. Other melodies, whole, suspended between song and speech in still the silence.

Water on the surface of the stone captures the light in motion and appeals for entry. All is entreat to stir inside the mass weight of the stone.

Render voices to meet the weight of stone with weight of voices.

Muted colors appear from the transparency of the white and wash the stone's periphery, staining the hue-less stone.
wall.
For the next phase. Next to last. Before the last. Before completing. Draw from stains the pigment as it spills from within, with in each repetition, extract even darker, the stain, until it falls in a single stroke of color, crimson, red, as a flame caught in air for its sustenance.

Stone to pigment. Stone. Wall.
Page.
To stone, water, teinture, blood.

All rise. At once. One by one. Voices absorbed into the bowl of sound. Rise voices shifting upwards circling the bowl's hollow. In deep metal voice spiraling up wards to pools no visible light lighter no audible higher quicken shiver the air in pool's waves to raise all else where all memory all echo

La tarea

TIME

¿Qué hora es?
Son las siete y media.
Todavía es temprano para acostarse.
Mi trabajo es una porquería.

POSSESSION

El dinero no es tuyo, es del jefe.

FOR WHOM SOMETHING IS DESTINED

Esta carta es para mí.
Esta bolsa es " "

SUBSTANCE OR MATERIAL

Los sobres y los sellos son de papel.

ORIGIN

Friduchita es de México.

IMPERSONAL EXPRESSION

Es estupendo tener tanta confianza.
Es raro encontrar un hombre como él.

WITH NOUNS AND PRONOUNS

Mi hermano es un estudiante.
El gran peligro es el frío.
¿Eres tú Matilde?

Dream

I was in a car with my family. It was a winter night. They were going home and so was I. My father stopped the car on a residential street some distance from our house. My parents said that they would leave me there, in the middle of a snowy boulevard lined with large houses, because I could hitchhike home.

On the street I walk around as if I were an ant in a farm zig-zagging through cars, people, streets. The grossness of New York seems to weigh me down today, I feel very small, a somber snail. I feel as if my body is so burdened by such a concentration of enormity in buildings, moving walls of people, cacaphony of sounds, everything leaping, running, shouting in different directions at once that I could become a giant drill spinning so fast that I could burrow into the ground, then stop. Nothing, dead, a petrified tree, hard, and brittle. People put on set faces and acquire determined strides in the city. To be soft is to be trampled. My good moods and smiles for the world are sliced by scowls and indifferent stares. Desperation is everywhere. From the nervous mouse glances of men in business suits at their watches to the gray-colored men and women who possessively carry bags and bags of garbage. Misery weighs me down, pulls my head from a cloud of abstraction. Oppression is everywhere, seen and unseen.

RITUAL

There is a small bog on the tundra about three minutes outside of town. The bog is littered with pieces of plywood blown by the fierce Arctic winds from various construction sites. The mighty winter winds and the permafrost leave only a few months for building. The construction crews work twenty-four hours a day under the midnight sun. Chasing a few pieces of plywood that have been carried off by the High Arctic winds is not a good reason to put down your tools.

Under those pieces of plywood is shelter from the wind for a myriad of species. The plywood becomes home in the vast treelessness. The wood becomes a dark sanctuary safe from all the predators. We find creatures underneath the plywood, from beetles and baby birds to lemmings. The lemmings are my favourite. They get so startled as I rip off the ceiling from their safety, blindly running to find escape from this monster that has changed their world.

After chasing and capturing them I hold each one in my cupped hands, singing to it until its heartbeat returns to normal cadence. I put them in my pockets. Don't put more than one in each pocket or they will start fighting. Not many creatures are good in overpopulated spaces. I have about six pockets in my windbreaker. Six lemmings a day keeps the doctor away.

Whistling my way home and brimming with anticipation for my daily ritual; I have only five lemmings today. There is a small back porch in our house. Since nobody ever uses the back door, the porch is my domain. It's a good place to hide things, a good place to pretend the rest of the world is mine. Stopping at the fridge to pick out a few carrots and some celery, I then lay the lemmings out on the floor of the bare porch. The carrots belong in the corner. The animals are afraid at first, but cannot resist the smorgasbord of food. I leave them happily munching and starting to relax.

We have a fish tank in our living room. There are newts, snails, and fish in there. The snails procreate too quickly for the health of the tank, so my ritual begins by killing off a minimum of ten snails by simply squishing their little bodies against the glass, shells and all. It is very satisfying to me to hear their shells popping, like when you find a particularly dirty part on the rug while you are vacuuming, and it all clinks up the tube in a hollow symphony.

Part two of my ritual is to take one of the newts by the tail and put it into my mouth. It sits there on my tongue, the little suction cups on its toes grasping my taste buds. I close

my mouth. It crawls around in confusion for a minute, and then finds comfort in the heat and darkness. It squirms its way under my tongue, and usually falls asleep there. I do some chores as it rests, opening my mouth to let some fresh air in. I go and look into the bathroom mirror. The newt is almost always sleeping, its cute little eyes closed and restful, using my tongue as a huge duvet. I find it adorable. I return him to the tank, and go to find my furry friends.

The lemmings are fed and full. I lie down in the small porch. I can fit lengthwise in the porch if my knees are bent. I fan out my long hair on the floor and wait. I lie still. The lemmings calm, and begin to stir. They find my hair. This awakens their burrowing instinct. They make their way to my scalp, seeking safety. The smallest of paws massaging my head at lightning speed. They never leave the safety of my hair. They keep going for about ten minutes before they get weary of attempting to dig. It's the best ten minutes of my day. It's still the best massage I have ever gotten. Once they tire, I put them back into my pockets and return them to where I found them. I have to get them out before my parents come home. The lemmings are full of carrots and happy. I will come back tomorrow. My mother once found one small piece of lemming poop in my hair. She laughed so hard and wondered how it got in there. I told her I was lying down on the tundra. I have kept this small ritual to myself until now.

Something is lurking
Something sideways
Something hollow
Something pasty and shallow
Something jittery
Something slow
Sucking on mud and
Filled with woe

Something is stirring
Something full
Something thick and cold
Something imperceptible
Something unseen
Something war-driven
Something obscene

It makes me want to hide in blankets and make bad choices
It makes me want to destroy what's in front of me
It can be freed only with tears

Language is a map of failures. Messy thoughts on reading, writing and dressing up by Runa Borch Skolseg

Every morning when I get up, I pull a thin, light, blue dress over my head while making coffee. I think about how the clothes I wear can affect what I write. I often note what I wear to remember if it's a good set for writing or not. Yesterday I wore a pair of black shorts and a pink t-shirt. The shorts I stole from a man I dated several years ago, they are from an expensive brand and made of silk. When I wear them it is as if I was not wearing any clothes at all. He was narrow through the hips and when we fucked I could feel his hip bone pressing against mine.

I have a big yellow shirt from Martin Margiela that goes all the way down to my knees. I inherited it from my sister who got it from her ex-husband. She didn't want it hanging in her closet, it reminded her too much of him. When he left them she threw out a whole lot of clothes, there was something rational about how she acted. Something about how clothes frame the body and remind us how the world and clothing are an intermediate station that lie and swing between something linguistic and not. Clothes can be seen and experienced in several ways, that is also the act of reading, clothes shape the way we meet the world, but also the way the world looks back at us, reads us. Clothes leave traces, they are about touch, surface, what is in contact with the skin but also the world.

My grandmother was a reader, she read Kierkegaard and Virginia Woolf. When I lied to her as a child, she looked at me and quoted Freud, *from error to error one discovers the entire truth*.

I have a lot of books inherited from friends of my parents, one of them was Kitty, a professor of psychology. At her funeral they played 'I'm so excited', I thought that was weird. Among Kitty's old books I found Julia Kristeva, Simone Weil and Hélène Cixous.

I read and I always wanted more, it was an obsession to discover the power of reading and the possibility of being read.

My mother gave me Karen Blixen, Sylvia Plath and Ingeborg Bachmann. Reading my mother's books and underlinings, I felt I was entering a secret room, a secret place that only we shared.

A couple of months after my ex-boyfriend's sudden death I helped his mother empty the apartment, she said I could take whatever I wanted, I didn't really want anything, but this seemed a bit dramatic since the apartment had also been my home for six years. On our first date he gave me a 1st edition of Pessoa. I thought it was a very white, straight-man book to give, inside he had written a dedication. He gave me other books too, Sontag's *Notes on Camp*, Robert Bresson and Ursula Andkjær Olsen. He had a very ugly shirt from his father's home town in Iran. It was red, white, pink and yellow, and every weekend he wore it reading in bed or on the sofa. It was his reading shirt and it still smells like him, a mix of pomelo, black pepper and sweat.

When I think of all the books or clothes and how they came to be on my bookshelves, it is as if I carry many lines, times and generations in me at once. I carry the exchange between mother and daughter, between partners, from one friend to another.

The ancient Greek myths warn us about the danger of recognizing only our own reality. Art is a way into other realities, other personalities. When a book touches me I let new desires in. The book doesn't reproduce me, it redefines me and pushes boundaries. Great art works on the border of our memory and changes what already exists. It couldn't do that if it already reflected what existed.

Jeanette Winterson writes in an essay about exceptional sensibility, about writers who have an early warning system, an immanence that allows him, her or hen to recognize and articulate the emotional perplexities of their age. The emotional and psychic resonance of a particular people at a particular time is not a series of snapshots that can be stuck together to make a montage; it is a living, breathing and winding movement that flows out of the past and into the future while making its present unique.

As in early ancient Greece we keep asking ourselves about the relation between reader and writer. It could be worth asking what it is that they want from one another, as it seems like we have returned to a place where play, pose and experiment are unwelcome and where the idea of art is debased.

I can't stop writing my essay to Mette. I was happy about it, but then I started to re-read and re-think, and now I am making it even more fragmented than it was.

It is hot, even though it's March.

I tell a friend about this essay, about reading and dressing up and the living books, and he tells me that he just read a report on a psychological phenomenon that the two researchers Hajo Adams and Adam Galinsky call enclothed cognition. Their study showed how, for example, doctors did a better job when they wore their doctor coats. It was not that anyone could become a doctor by wearing the coat, but that professionals sharpened their practice by dressing.

I think about whether some of the living books not only channel the voice of the book, but also dress up as the book and wear a certain piece of cloth when they are memorizing the book, or if the clothing could be a way to remember?

I remember things through my clothes. I remember sitting on the grass in a short dress in Berlin reading Elvia Wilk. It was so hot, my thighs started itching. The sentence *when I was little my sister used to tell me that if I could lick my own elbow I would turn into a boy* pops into my head whenever I see the dress hanging in my closet.

On the second of June, 2021, when left
was right and I kept pushing against every
attempt to put down any words—how
could the world say anything after her
passing? Is death a mistranslation? What
about her language, her sounds?

كتبتُ بلغة المنفى لأجد شـيئاً مِن الأمّ في ركام المعاني؟ هل
يجـد المرء أمّه في منفى اللغة؟ في

Her body remained without her in the
، form, I could no longer write in any

الشـعر؟ في صمت الكلمات؟ لم يبق لي إلّا السؤال وكل
الأجوبـة تبقى معلّقة مؤجّلة؟ تلك هي

adopted sound, poetry was left behind
without its source; I only wanted to

لغتي، تلك هي أمّي، وهذه كلّ قصائدها: صمتٌ يحثّ على
السؤال وأسئلة لا تقبل الإجابات...

hear her voice, but there was that silence, the language she
mastered, and the mother
tongue happened to be Arabic—everything she said, and
didn't say like the sword, one
and cutting through everything real, in a reality devoid of
speech ~~her sounds I could not write in any form~~
and all she could remember of her English lessons, is the
phrase
that made fun of her inability to be with anything but Arabic
she said, that all she remembers

13

of English, a half definition, that "an inventor is a man or
woman..." I can see her clearly, strangely
when she was near the light, by the frame of the door to her
bedroom saying those only English words she spoke,
to laugh with me, to laugh at herself, and to always make
sure I remember that
school lessons
are not to be taken seriously.
[I wish you could do things without the mind
she always said: a craft of some sort to save you from those
lessons your father gives]—
تتراكـم ذرّات الصمت هذه هنا وهناك. أجمُعها ذرّةً ذرّةً.
أسـترجع بها هزائمي مع العربية، لغتي التي لا أقوى عليها
الآن. لأنّي لو قويـتُ عليها لرددتُها ـ كما قالها الأوائل ـ قالباً
قالبـاً. وأنا الذي لا أجيد ترديد الأقوال، بل أردّد الأصوات
التي حضنتْني، أردّد أصواتهم علّني ألتقط بعضاً من أصداء
صمتهـم، ثم أودّعهم عندما يحين وقت الكتابة.
My defeats with the Arabic language keep
up keep me up yup the American
English of NOPE.

THE DISAPPEARANCE

Chalky steps: chair hugging chair
not long ago, all was well, and then
one on top of the other—they've been
stacked: tables all smothered by stiff
legs and some hard flat bellies, and
not much more happened after that. Every
one remained where they'd been placed.
A strange arrangement has just taken place:

Without the sitters they felt themselves
kings for once, on top of the world, so
to speak, and that was that, for a while
till they began feeling an itch for what
"used to be," for "the old times" when they were
murdered every day, and people sat there

to witness.

ينتهـي الفصل الأول من الضياع. هلعٌ كلُّ هذا النثر والهذر.
هلعٌ ألمّ باللغة وبالكلمات.

Here ends the first chapter of exile. Beginnings once more,
now I stray—
Was Arabic a home? Wasn't it my initial exile
to begin with, to begin again, another chapter of it
in this English tongue

here is this prose, a nothing but...

I *am entirely incapable of producing, let alone reproducing...*
Things as Thighs: What?! What do
they say: that *all translation?*
Essentially are, after all—some
common error:
misgivings**?** And after
reading so many Russian novels

I want to drink whiskey
out of a spatula:
I go around asking—

strange that no liquor store
in new york city
has them.

I say to myself

(we always have to say
something
to this thing
misnamed
§elf)

here is elsewhere
here,

in this land of new beginnings
I own no language:
giving things names
that do not belong to them

is as easy as a mistake

(FIG)

I

And the worst was discovering the fig trees in the city—their leaves die and dry at first contact with the cold. I pass the one that was first pointed out to me. There is no trunk to this tree, it's all bare branches now. In summer it never looked like a tree either. More like a bush it was. Some heaviness in the air always pushing it down, never allowing it to extend to the sky like the fig it's supposed to be. The one stuck in memory. I never dared taste its fruit. I picked them from the branch a couple of times and watched their milk ooze out from the stem. And when touched, the milk didn't seem thick enough and that was that: only an image you keep in mind, and in the fall only this bare trunk that used to hold the only thing that gave it away: its miracle of leaves.

II

The old world and the Americas are straying apart at a rate of two centimeters per year, and Home is getting farther away from where I left it, and I am, despite my thread of longing, getting ahead of myself.

III

I hold the moment to a mirror. I lose focus or increase it to some point—and when I lose it completely, I am… after all, a vase of stale air.

rife*